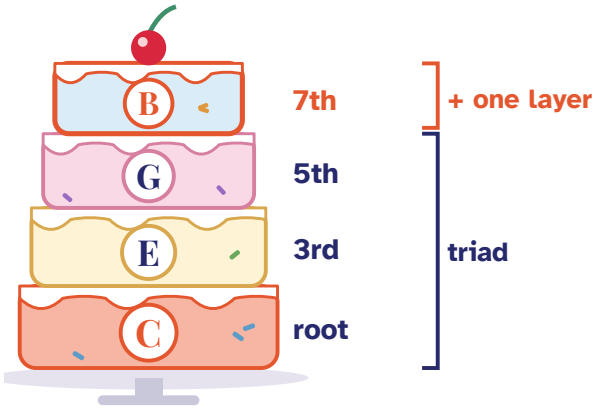
PART IV · CHORDS · 5

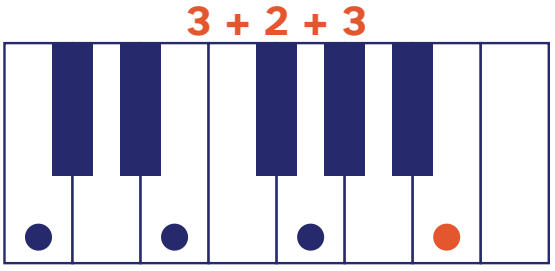
# Seventh chords

Add one more layer to the cake and the chord changes colour: dreamy, bluesy, spooky. Same rule as before: skip one note, stack the next. The new note is the **7th**.

**THE SECRET**
**One more layer on the cake and the chord changes colour.**




1. Build the triad: **C E G**.
2. Skip one, add the next: **B**.
3. Count the keys between: **3 + 2 + 3**. That is **Cmaj7**.




## Five flavours, all on C

| Cmaj7 | C7 | Cm7 | Cø7 | C°7 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 3 + 2 + 3 | 3 + 2 + 2 | 2 + 3 + 2 | 2 + 2 + 3 | 2 + 2 + 2 |
| C E G B | C E G B♭ | C E♭ G B♭ | C E♭ G♭ B♭ | C E♭ G♭ B𝄫 |
| **dreamy** | **bluesy** | **mellow** | **searching** | **spooky** |
| bossa nova, film | the blues | soul, jazz ballads | jazz, film noir | old film villains |

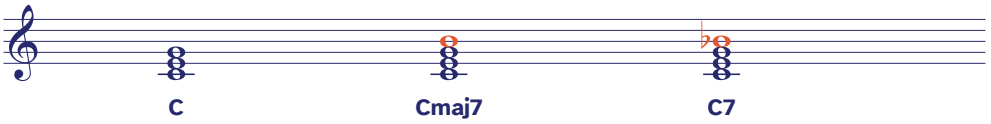
How the names work: major triad + major 7th = **maj7** · major triad + minor 7th = **7** · minor triad + minor 7th = **m7** · diminished triad + minor 7th = **ø7** · diminished triad + diminished 7th = **°7**.

## A seventh on every note of C major




Only white keys: count the keys between to name each one.

PART IV · CHORDS · 5 · CONTINUED

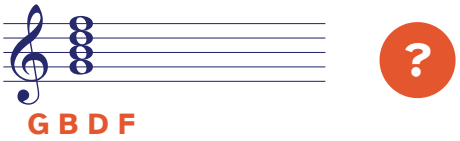



One note decides: B makes Cmaj7, B♭ makes C7. Everything below stays the same.

## Spot the difference

EXAMPLE 1

**Which seventh is it? G B D F**




1. **Count the keys between** each layer: G to B, B to D, D to F.
2. **Which of the five flavours** has those three numbers?
3. **The root is G.** Name the chord.

3 + 2 + 2, the bluesy one, on G: **G7**.

GAME

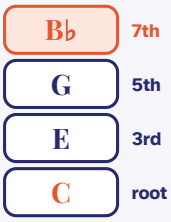
**Which seventh?**

| 1 | 2 | 3 |
|---|---|---|
| F A C E | C E G B♭ | D F A C |

A cake with one more layer. Name each chord.

Answer: 1 Fmaj7 · 2 C7 · 3 Dm7.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



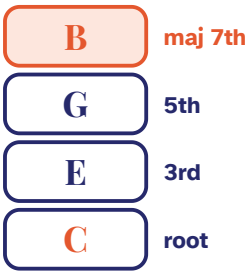

**Play C7, then Cmaj7.**

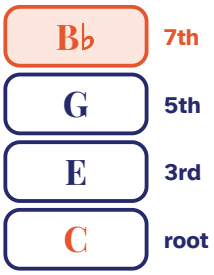
C E G B♭, then C E G B. One key changes the top layer: bluesy, then dreamy.

PART IV · CHORDS · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

### Cmaj7 or C7: which note changes?



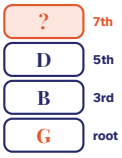




1. **Both start with C major:** C E G.
2. **Compare the top layers.** Which one note is different?
3. **Count the keys between** G and the top layer in each.

Only the top layer changes: **B** (3 between) is Cmaj7, **B♭** (2 between) is C7.

EXAMPLE 3

### Build G7

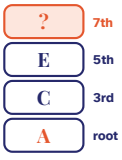



1. **Build G major:** G B D.
2. **Skip one more letter** above D: which?
3. **Count the keys between** D and it: 2 (the bluesy 7) or 3 (maj7)?

G B D **F**: 3 + 2 + 2, so it is **G7**.

EXAMPLE 4

### Build Am7




1. **Build A minor:** A C E (2 + 3).
2. **Add the next letter** but one above E.
3. **Count the keys between** E and the new layer.

A C E **G**: 2 + 3 + 2, so it is **Am7**.

TRAP

- × Writing C7 when you mean Cmaj7: "7" alone means the bluesy one, with B♭.
- × Stacking the 7th from the wrong note: count a 7th up from the root, not from the 5th.

SEE ALSO
Four kinds of triad p. 90 · Chords in a key p. 93

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 5 · Online: Library › Chords